

Asia Communacopia + Technology – Key Takeaways: Axera Chair visit: AI inference SoC for smart vehicles and edge AI; In-house NPU with high

Asia Communacopia + Technology
18 – 19 May 2026 | Hong Kong
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We hosted Axera (0600.HK, Not covered) Chair at our Asia Communacopia + Technology conference (May 18–19) in Hong Kong. Key discussions were around (1) edge AI SoC opportunities, (2) new product pipeline with client penetration, and (3) technology advantages. The company focuses on growth opportunities in smart vehicles and edge AI inference, and management is positive on the rising penetration of L2+ smart vehicles, and edge computing opportunities driven by the industrial agents and AI personal agents. Mgmt. also highlights on-device AI computing starting the upgrade and replacement cycle.

Read across: Management's comment on strong demand for smart vehicles and edge AI devices echo our positive view on AI chips ecosystem expansion in China. We are positive on the rising client spending driven by emerging AI applications, new requirement on higher efficiency, lower latency etc., and the accelerated localization rate.

Company profile: Axera (0600.HK) is the AI inference SoC supplier for edge and endpoint AI applications including smart vehicles. The company's SoC is based on its won Axera Neutron mixed-precision NPU (Neural Processing Unit) to deliver the improved AI inference efficiency. For automotive OEM and Tier-1 clients, the company provides M55H SoC and M76H SoC products, and continues to gain new design-wins.

Key Takeaways

1. New product pipeline: For smart vehicles applications, the company has started mass production of AI SoC incl. M55H and M76H for L2+ features like highway NOA and urban ICA (Intelligent cruise assist). The company is working on the new product M97 SoC for high-level smart driving, which was taped out in Oct 2025, and successfully brought up upon chip return in Feb 2026. For edge AI applications, besides 8830 and 8850 series SoC, management notes the company is also developing next-generation edge LLM AI inference chip with higher operating frequencies and higher computing power.

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2. In-house mixed-precision NPU: Axera develops the mixed precision NPU (Axera Neutron) in-house for smart vehicles and edge AI applications, with its AI algorithms and underlying hardware. To deploy the AI models in edge or on-device, management notes the company breaks through the data and memory bottlenecks, adopts more concise data representations and lower the redundancy of weights/ feature values to improve the computational efficiency. We see the company developing solutions with enhanced processing speed, and clients could select different numerical precision based on their demand.

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